

an ecosystem which will also suit more aspirational categories. We will have to address all the problems one by one.”

One of the biggest problems to solve around the EV ecosystem is sourcing of the raw materials used in manufacturing open cells and battery packs. The magnitude of this problem can be ascertained from the fact that big automotive companies like BMW have started acquiring stake in mining companies.

“Lithium, cobalt, and nickel are found concentrated in different parts of the world. Solving this problem is of utmost importance for creating a robust electric vehicle ecosystem. This problem intensifies its nature in India as we are a very price-sensitive country. Even small changes in sourcing costs can create havoc in the EV market here. We should start here and then move towards step two,” according to Verma.

Are EV prices a deterrent in the adoption rate?

The EVs available in India, in comparison to their ICE versions, are priced quite highly. For instance, an EV variant of Tata Nexon is retailed at a starting price of 1.4 million rupees (ex-showroom). However, Tata retails the ICE variants of Tata Nexon at starting prices that are almost half of that price tag (670,000 rupees, ex-showroom). Similarly, MG retails ZS EV at starting price of 2.8 million rupees, whereas MG Hector (ICE) is retailed at starting price of around 1.2 million rupees only.

“Compared to financing options available on ICE engine-powered cars, we do not get the same support in terms of EVs. This fact becomes more challenging when it comes to three-wheeler EVs. If bankers agree on giving loans in this category of EVs, it will help create trust in the minds of the people,” explains Reddy.

The finance options on EVs might also help in lowering the burden of upfront costs attached to owning these. As EVs come loaded with many more features than a normal ICE-engine car, their cost automatically goes up. But a lot of people buy cars, bikes, or commercial vehicles on a limited budget in India.

Reddy notes, “We build telematics solutions for EVs used in commercial operations. Usually, people are not willing to pay extra for such features. Even if we try to build a performance vehicle, the limited budgets of people would not allow them to invest in buying one. What we have done to help people test our EVs is that we are giving our EV models to them for use on the OPEX model.”

OPEX model, as per Reddy, can be a stepping-stone for increasing the adoption rate of EVs in India. In an OPEX model, a company or an individual does not generally buy a product. It is more like a pay-as-you-go service, or kind of a lease service, where one only pays for the time one uses a product.

“We also need corporates to encourage their employees to use EVs for daily transportation. These corporates can also encourage to invest in EVs for their day-to-day transportation needs. If the corporates start encouraging employees then the bankers will not hesitate in financing EVs,” opines Reddy.

The other way to bring down overall cost and make people experience what EVs can do is by offering them the battery-swapping model. As Kartikey Hariyani, founder and CEO, TecSo explains, a battery swapping programme by an EV company could be the answer to the most important question in India about vehicles: ‘Kitna Deti Hai?’ (What is the mileage?)

“At the customer end, we can remove half his headache by introducing the battery-as-a-service model. This simply means that the cost of ownership comes down as well as the trouble associated with EV batteries is done away with. The EV makers should tell the consumer that we are doing this to help minimise your risk,” advises Hariyani.

He adds, “If the customer knows that I am only buying a vehicle and the battery problems will be taken care of by the brand, he will feel empowered to buy and experience an EV.

Can data help in insuring and financing EVs?

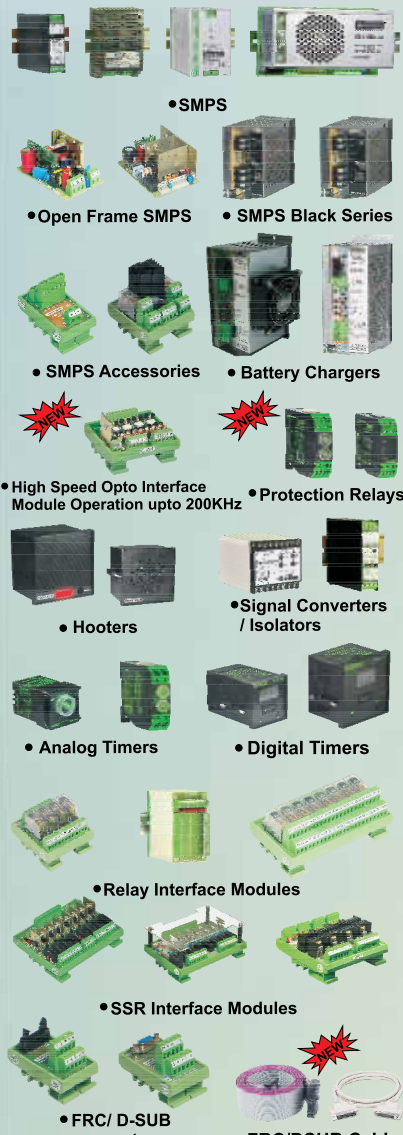
In terms of ICE-powered car and bike models, there is enough data available



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